

Reflection: Capturing a Trip vs. Being Present in It

Core Observation

While watching a video about two people traveling, I noticed that one person appeared to be on his phone almost constantly. The scenery around him looked beautiful, yet the footage repeatedly showed him walking through it while focused on a screen. The video made me wonder whether he was really experiencing the place he had traveled to, or mainly collecting a record of it.

I understand the desire to take photographs and videos. Images can preserve moments, help people share experiences with friends and family, and provide something meaningful to revisit later. But there is an important difference between documenting an experience and allowing documentation to become the experience itself.

A Record Is Not the Experience

A photo or video is a reflection of a place, not the place itself. It can capture a view, a building, weather, a meal, or a moment, but it cannot fully replace being there: looking around, noticing the atmosphere, hearing the sounds, feeling the temperature, observing the architecture, or spending time with the person who traveled with you.

This is what stood out to me in the video. I kept thinking: put the phone away for a moment and look around. If someone returns from a trip and cannot describe where they went, what they saw, how the environment felt, or what they did because everything exists only on their phone, that would feel disappointing. The trip would be preserved as media, but perhaps not as a lived memory.

The Missing Shared Experience

Another detail that felt strange was that the two people traveling together were rarely shown interacting with one another. Instead, the footage repeatedly showed one individual on his phone while moving through the location alone. That may not represent the whole trip, because any edited video is selective, but it still creates a particular impression: the person seems disconnected from both the environment and their companion.

A trip is not only about reaching a destination. It can also be about shared attention—looking at something together, talking about what you notice, getting lost, discovering an unexpected detail, or simply being quiet in a place that feels different from home. When constant phone use takes over, those moments can be reduced or missed entirely.

Why This Matters on Travel

Travel places people in environments they do not normally experience. A cruise, a city in another country, a historic neighborhood, a forest trail, or a snowy street in Japan can offer details that cannot be fully communicated through a screen:

- The scale and design of the architecture
- The weather, lighting, sound, and movement of a place
- The rhythm of people walking, working, or gathering
- The feeling of unfamiliar streets, landscapes, and public spaces
- Small moments that would never be planned, photographed, or posted

For me, a trip to Japan would be something I would want to actively notice. I would take pictures, but I would not want photography or phone use to become the entire trip. I would want to appreciate the architecture, streets, rain, snow, scenery, and atmosphere directly. In that situation, being unreachable for a while would not feel like a loss; it would be part of being fully present.

Filming, Editing, and What the Viewer Sees

My reaction is also shaped by my experience studying film. In a bachelor's-level film course, I learned about choices such as three-point lighting, framing, visual composition, and the work involved in creating a final production. We watched films and videos to understand how footage is captured, edited, and presented to an audience.

A finished video never shows everything that happened. It is a constructed version of an event. The creator chooses what to include, what to exclude, how long to hold a shot, and what impression the audience should receive. Because of that, I recognize that the footage I watched may not show the entire reality of the travelers' experience.

Still, the repeated decision to show one person on a phone became meaningful. It shaped the story of the trip. Rather than making the location feel central, it made the screen feel central. The setting may have been visually impressive—possibly presented in high-resolution, cinematic footage—yet the person in the scene appeared unaware of the beauty around him.

A Personal Perspective on Screens and Memory

I do not think phones, photography, or travel videos are inherently bad. I enjoy watching forest walks, hiking footage, nature videos, and videos of people walking through Japan in snow or rain. Those recordings can be calming, informative, and inspiring. They can make distant places feel more accessible and can motivate someone to travel.

The issue is balance. A camera can help preserve a memory, but it should not prevent someone from forming one. A useful question might be: if every photo and video disappeared, would I still be able to describe this experience? Would I remember what I saw, how it felt, who I was with, and why it mattered?

If the answer is no, then it may be time to put the phone away and pay attention.

Conclusion

The video made me reflect on the difference between living a moment and producing content about a moment. Recording a trip has value, but travel should remain more than a collection of images on a device. The most meaningful part of being somewhere new is not only what can be captured and shown later. It is also the direct, unrecorded experience of looking around and realizing: I am here.